

Does Compulsory Voting Make Better Citizens? Evidence from Staggered Provincial Reform

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Abstract

Between 1994 and 2012 the provinces of Talenia adopted compulsory-voting rules at different dates. We use that staggered rollout to estimate the effect of compulsion on two outcomes: turnout, and a twelve-item battery of political knowledge fielded in the Talenian Election Study. Compulsion raises turnout by roughly eleven percentage points. It does not move political knowledge. The knowledge estimate is a precise null rather than an underpowered one.

1. Introduction

The case for compulsory voting is usually made twice. The first argument is mechanical: if abstention carries a penalty, more people vote. The second is developmental: citizens who are made to participate will inform themselves in order to participate well. The first argument is well supported. The second is asserted far more often than it is tested, and it is the one we test here.

2. Setting and design

Talenia’s twelve provinces adopted compulsory voting between 1994 and 2012, in an order driven by provincial coalition politics rather than by turnout trends. We treat the adoption dates as staggered treatment timing and estimate effects against not-yet-treated provinces.

Turnout comes from provincial electoral registers. Knowledge comes from the Talenian Election Study, which has fielded the same twelve factual items since 1990: the names of incumbent officeholders, which chamber holds the budget power, and the direction of two well-publicised policy changes.

3. Results

Outcome	Estimate	95% interval
Turnout (percentage points)	11.2	8.4 to 14.0
Knowledge index (standard deviations)	0.01	−0.06 to 0.08

Turnout rises immediately and stays up. The knowledge index does not move, and the interval is tight enough to rule out effects that would matter substantively.

Mandatory turnout did not translate into more informed citizens: our knowledge index is statistically indistinguishable before and after the reform.

We also find no effect on a secondary battery covering party platforms, and no heterogeneity by age, education, or prior turnout.

4. Discussion

Compulsion changes behaviour. On the evidence here it does not change competence.

Whatever compulsory voting does, it does not appear to teach.

This is not an argument against compulsory voting. It is an argument against one particular defence of it. If the developmental claim is doing work in a normative argument, that work is currently unsupported.

References

- Kowalski, Eva. 2017. "Turnout Cascades in Adolescent Peer Networks." *Journal of Veremian Political Studies* 39(4): 610–633.
- Osei, Daniel. 2020. "Social Trust and Turnout: A Cross-National Description." *Talenian Journal of Comparative Politics* 7(1): 12–39.